

Congestion, Sinus Problems, & Earache

Excessive nasal congestion is not always easy to treat and suggests poor air quality, inappropriate diet, or an allergy. The shape of the nose and sinuses (the air-filled cavities in the bones around the nose) can also play a role in this condition. Sinuses can become blocked with fluid, causing painful pressure. Earache may be caused by local infection—in which case garlic is particularly effective—or congestion. Lavender is helpful in soothing the pain of all types of earache.

Diet

As a first step, reduce foods thought to increase mucus production, such as dairy, eggs, fried and fatty food, sugar, and refined carbohydrates, such as white flour, as well as alcohol.

❗ **General caution** Seek professional advice for earache, especially in children.

General Remedy

Herb Eucalyptus (*Eucalyptus globulus*, p. 96)

Remedy Make a steam inhalation by infusing 15 g of herb, or put 5–10 drops of essential oil in 3 cups (750 ml) water. Inhale for 10 minutes.

Allergic States with Excessive Nasal Mucus, such as Hay Fever

Herb German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77)

Remedy Make a steam inhalation by infusing 15 g of herb, or put 5–10 drops of essential oil in 3 cups (750 ml) water. Inhale for 10 minutes.

Earache

Herb Lavender (*Lavandula officinalis*, p. 108)

Remedy Place 2 drops of essential oil on a cotton ball and plug into the ear.

Earache Caused by Infection

Herb Garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59)

Remedy Break open a garlic oil capsule, place 2 drops on a cotton ball, and plug into the affected ear. Alternatively, crush a large clove of garlic and soak in 1 tbsp of sunflower or olive oil for at least 24 hours. Strain the oil and warm it to body temperature. Then place 2 drops on a cotton ball and plug into the ear.

Earache due to Chronic Congestion

Herbs Echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92), thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143), marshmallow (*Althaea officinalis*, p. 165), elderflower (*Sambucus nigra*, p. 132)

Remedy Mix equal parts of each tincture and take 1 tsp 3 times a day with water.

Copious Liquid Mucus & Sinus Congestion

See *Allergic Rhinitis*, p. 300.

Sinus Headaches

See *Tension & Sinus Headaches*, p. 309.

Musculoskeletal Problems



Cramp bark
(*Viburnum opulus*)

Whether caused by accident, sports injury, or simple wear and tear, musculoskeletal problems can lead to a significant deterioration in quality of life. Manipulation is often the primary treatment, but herbal remedies can reduce pain and inflammation, relax muscles, detoxify the body, and speed up the rate of healing. External treatments soothe back muscles and joints, and sprained or sore limbs. Persevering with the simple home treatments given below can bring about a marked improvement of many problems.

❗ Seek immediate professional advice for:

- Severe pain
- Significant or sudden joint swelling
- Broken or suspected broken bones
- Any injury that may need an X-ray

❗ **Caution** Only give external remedies to children. Seek professional advice before giving internal remedies to them.

Sprains & Fractures

Minor damaged areas benefit from herbs such as arnica and comfrey, which soothe bruising and speed up the healing process. Apply as soon as possible after treatment.

❗ **General caution** Always seek professional treatment for broken bones, fractures, and severe sprains.

Sprains

Herb Arnica (*Arnica montana*, p. 172)

Remedy Apply ointment or cream to the damaged area and gently massage into the skin at least 3 times a day.

Caution Do not use arnica on broken skin.

Fractures

Herb Comfrey (*Symphytum officinale*, p. 138)

Remedy Gently apply ointment, cream, or infused oil to the area at least 3 times a day.

Caution Do not use comfrey on broken skin.

Muscle Aches & Cramps

Muscle aches and cramps are entirely normal, particularly after strenuous activity, and the pain should lessen in time. Meanwhile, rubs and ointments containing soothing herbs, such as arnica, thyme, and cramp bark, can alleviate aching muscles. Rheumatism is a general term for muscle or joint pain and stiffness, and the remedies listed here and under *Joint Pain & Stiffness*, p. 313, are appropriate for this condition.

Tired & Aching Muscles

Herb Arnica (*Arnica montana*, p. 172)

Remedy Apply cream or ointment.

Caution Do not use arnica on broken skin.

Herbs Thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143), rosemary (*Rosmarinus officinalis*, p. 128)

Remedy Make an infusion with 25 g of one herb to 3 cups (750 ml) water. Brew for 10 minutes, strain into a bath, and soak for 20 minutes.

Option Try also the rub containing St. John's wort oil, listed under *General Remedies for Back Pain*, p. 313.

Cramps & Muscle Spasms

Herb Cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150)

Remedy (Internal) Take 1 tsp of tincture with water up to 3 times a day.

Remedy (External) Rub neat tincture firmly into the affected area.